

Morning School Routine Survival — Action Checklist

PRINT THIS PAGE AND KEEP IT SOMEWHERE VISIBLE

BUILD THE NIGHT-BEFORE SYSTEM

- ☐ **Build the Night-Before System:** Create a launchpad by setting up a labeled bin or basket near your door where each child stores their shoes, jacket, and backpack so everything is in one spot when it's time to leave.
- ☐ **Build the Night-Before System:** Establish a nightly routine between 8:00-8:30pm where kids pack backpacks with homework and signed forms, place lunch components in the fridge, and lay out tomorrow's clothes.
- ☐ **Build the Night-Before System:** Adjust the level of supervision based on your child's age by staying actively involved with ages 5-7, verifying their work for ages 8-10, and expecting full independence from ages 11-12.
- ☐ **Build the Night-Before System:** When the night-before routine doesn't happen, resist abandoning the entire system and instead accept that mornings will be harder while keeping priorities clear and getting dressed beats making lunch.

DESIGN THE MORNING CHART

- ☐ **Design the Morning Chart:** Build a 6-step visual chart showing the morning sequence with these boxes: wake up, get dressed, eat breakfast, brush teeth, pack up, and put on shoes ready to go.
- ☐ **Design the Morning Chart:** Include simple illustrations for each step on the chart since young children respond better to pictures than written text, especially kids under 8 years old.
- ☐ **Design the Morning Chart:** Build the chart WITH your child rather than FOR them to increase their investment in following it, which leads to better cooperation than top-down instructions.
- ☐ **Design the Morning Chart:** Add specific times to each step for children 8 and older by writing realistic wake-up, breakfast, and departure deadlines that come with actual consequences when missed.

MAINTAIN THE SYSTEM LONG-TERM

- ☐ **Maintain the System Long-Term:** Stop trying to manage each morning crisis individually and instead focus on building systems that prevent problems from happening in the first place.
 - ☐ **Maintain the System Long-Term:** Do the night-before routine consistently enough that occasional failures don't destroy your entire morning since the goal is managing exceptions, not achieving perfection.
 - ☐ **Maintain the System Long-Term:** Let natural consequences teach older children responsibility by making them pack their own lunch at 6am without your help when they skip the night-before prep.
 - ☐ **Maintain the System Long-Term:** Reframe how you think about chaotic mornings by recognizing it as a systems failure rather than a parenting failure, because systems can be redesigned but guilt cannot.
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Companion to the full guide in your Lemon Squeezy library — check off each item as you complete it.